TIKSCALE
THUMBNAIL DESIGN PLAYBOOK

Internal Training Document - Thumbnail Designers Only

If they don't click, they don't watch

1. Your Role as a TikScale Thumbnail Designer

Your job is simple: take a video title and concept brief and turn it into a thumbnail that gets clicked. That's the only metric that matters. Not how good it looks in isolation. Not how much work went into it. Does it make someone stop scrolling and click?

The thumbnail is the most important part of any video's performance. A great video with a bad thumbnail barely gets seen. A well-optimised thumbnail on a decent video can drive ten times the views. If the thumbnail doesn't work, nothing else matters.

When you receive an assignment, you'll have:

- The final video title
- Any specific direction from the strategist on concept or style
- Access to the client's existing thumbnail library and channel for reference

If the brief is unclear or missing information, flag it before you start. Don't design on assumptions.

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2. Core Design Principles

Everything in thumbnail design comes back to one goal: getting the click. These principles drive CTR. Follow them on every thumbnail.

2.1 The Glance Test

The average viewer looks at a thumbnail for under a second - often milliseconds. They are not reading carefully. They are scanning. Your thumbnail must communicate its core message in a single glance.

How to run the glance test: shrink the thumbnail to mobile size (roughly 1/6th of a phone screen). Look at it for one second. If the core message is unclear, the design fails. Most thumbnails fail this test because they contain too many elements competing for attention.

RULE: If you have to squint to read the text, it's too small. If you have to study the image to understand it, it's too complex. Design for the glance, not the stare.

2.2 Three Elements MaximMaybe examples of good scripts, good thumbnails, good idea docs and why they were good um

Every thumbnail should contain a maximum of three design elements. Not three categories - three total items. More than three and the design becomes cluttered, the message dilutes, and the click doesn't happen.

The seven element categories to choose from:

- Face with emotion
- Visually compelling graphic
- Large text, numbers, or dollars
- Aesthetic imagery
- Maximalist design collage
- Red circles or arrows (used alongside other elements, not as a standalone)
- Color contrast (a property of other elements, not an element itself)

A typical high-performing thumbnail uses three of these - for example: face + text + graphic. Pick the three that best communicate the desire loop for that specific video. Never try to fit all seven.

DO THIS	NOT THIS
Face with clear shocked expression + 4-word text + one strong graphic element	Face + text + graphic + arrow + logo + background pattern + secondary text
Two large contrasting words that reinforce the title	A paragraph of text trying to explain the video

REAL EXAMPLE: 'How to Find Your First 10 Cleaning Business Clients in 7 Days'

Three elements only:
- Subject (man in uniform holding cleaning supplies) - communicates the niche and professionalism instantly
- 'neighbor' and 'friends' labels positioned at the two figures in the background - these ARE the three elements alongside the subject, each one adds meaning without clutter
- The background scene (residential houses, people) provides visual context without competing

Nothing small. Nothing hidden. Everything readable in under a second at mobile size.

2.3 The Desire Loop - Design Around the Click Motivation

Before you open Photoshop, you need to understand what is driving the click. Every video targets a desire loop - the emotional or practical outcome the viewer wants. For business and coaching content, it is almost always one of three things: make more money, save time, or avoid a specific pain.

Your thumbnail must visually reinforce that desire loop. Ask yourself before designing:

- What does the viewer want to feel when they click this?
- What pain are they trying to escape, or what outcome are they chasing?
- What visual - a face, a graphic, a number - communicates that feeling immediately?

EXAMPLE: 'Watch Me Use AI to Create 30 Days of Viral LinkedIn Posts'

Desire loop: marketers and business owners want to grow on LinkedIn without spending hours creating content

Pain: content creation is slow and inconsistent

What this thumbnail does right:

- Face with a neutral, credible expression (not over-the-top) - signals this is a serious business channel
- ChatGPT + LinkedIn logos as the graphic element - immediately signals the tool and the platform, zero ambiguity
- '+1.7M VIEWS' stat in a bold text box - the result is front and centre, activates the desire loop instantly
- Three elements only: face, logos, stat box
- Dark background makes all three elements pop with strong contrast

Do NOT: show a generic laptop or social media icons with no result - that tells the viewer nothing about why they should click

2.4 Title and Thumbnail Work Together - Never Repeat Each Other

The title and thumbnail are a team. The title communicates one thing. The thumbnail communicates something that adds to it - it does not repeat what the title already says.

Think of the thumbnail text as the emotional or visual layer that sits underneath the title. If the title says 'How I Built a $100k Business', the thumbnail text should not say 'I Built a $100k Business'. It should reinforce the feeling - something like 'From Scratch' or a screenshot of the revenue.

DO THIS	NOT THIS

Title: 'The RIGHT Way to Use ManyChat in 2026' / Thumbnail text: 'Most coaches get this wrong' - adds new information and emotional tension	Title: 'The RIGHT Way to Use ManyChat in 2026' / Thumbnail text: 'ManyChat 2026 Guide' - repeats the title, adds nothing
Title: 'How I Closed $15k Deals with No Following' / Thumbnail: screenshot of contract or revenue + shocked face	Title: 'How I Closed $15k Deals with No Following' / Thumbnail: just text saying '$15k deals'

2.5 Emotion on the Face Must Match the Promise

If the client's face is in the thumbnail, the expression must match the emotional experience the viewer should have when they watch the video. This is not optional. The wrong expression on the right thumbnail concept will underperform every time.

Common expressions and when to use them:

- Shocked or surprised - use for revelation content, counterintuitive findings, 'I can't believe this worked' videos
- Confident or serious - use for authority content, strategy breakdowns, professional credibility videos
- Smiling or happy - use for success stories, results videos, transformation proof
- Concerned or intense - use for warning content, 'stop doing this' videos, problem-awareness content

REAL EXAMPLE: 'How To Pass the CompTIA Security+ 701 Exam On Your First Try'

The subject is smiling - a genuine, warm expression that says 'I did this and you can too'. The graphic element (the 'Congrats You Have Passed' certification screen on a laptop) is the result made visible. Together they create an instant emotional hit: this person passed, they're happy about it, here's the proof.

If the subject had a neutral or stressed expression, the thumbnail would communicate doubt instead of confidence. The smile is doing critical work here alongside the result graphic.

NOTE: The era of the exaggerated wide-open mouth is over, especially for business and coaching channels. Over-the-top shock faces damage credibility. Match the expression to the content type - a business coaching channel should look credible, not like a prank channel.

2.6 Color Contrast - Stand Out in the Feed

Your thumbnail exists in a feed surrounded by competitors. If everyone in the niche uses dark backgrounds, a light thumbnail will stand out. If everyone uses blue, try orange. Contrast within the thumbnail and contrast against the feed are both important.

Within the thumbnail:

- Use vivid, high-saturation colors that pop against the background
- White elements against dark backgrounds, dark elements against light backgrounds
- Orange against blue is one of the highest-contrast combinations available
- Avoid muted or desaturated colors - they disappear in the feed

Specific color rules:

- Green and red are the only colors universally understood as 'good' and 'bad' - use them intentionally for comparison content
- Avoid placing design elements in the bottom-right corner - YouTube's timestamp covers this area
- Apply saturation and brightness adjustments in Photoshop to keep everything looking crisp and vivid

2.7 Text Must Stick Out First

When text is part of the thumbnail, it must be the highest point of contrast on the page. Everything else in the design is supporting the text. If the image competes with the text for attention, you have a hierarchy problem.

How to make text stick out:

- Make it the highest contrast element - white text on dark backgrounds, or dark text on bright backgrounds
- Use large, bold fonts - if it looks too big in the design file, it's probably right at thumbnail size
- Point arrows at the text if needed to direct the eye
- Keep the rest of the design simple so nothing competes

- Keep text to four words or fewer wherever possible - the thumbnail is not a place for sentences

DO THIS	NOT THIS
4 words maximum, huge font, highest contrast element on screen	A full sentence explaining what the video is about
Text colour contrasted sharply against whatever is behind it	Text colour that blends into the background or graphic

2.8 Use Shadows to Create Separation

When the subject and background elements are visually competing - when the face blends into the background, or text sits over a complex image - use shadows and shading to create separation. Most designers skip this. They shouldn't.

- Add a drop shadow behind the subject to lift them off the background
- Use a subtle dark overlay or gradient behind text to ensure readability
- Shadows create visual depth and make the composition look more professional

3. Composition - How to Lay Out the Elements

Once you know your three elements and the desire loop, you need to decide how to arrange them. There are three composition types we use. Each works for different content.

3.1 Symmetrical

The main subject is centred. Both sides of the frame are roughly equal. Use this when the subject itself is the focus - a strong face, a compelling visual - and the layout doesn't need to imply movement or contrast.

3.2 Asymmetrical (Rule of Thirds)

The main subject sits one-third from the left or right of the frame. The remaining two-thirds carries the text or graphic. This is the most common and flexible composition. It creates visual movement and gives the text space to breathe without fighting the subject.

REAL EXAMPLE: 'How to Find Your First 10 Cleaning Business Clients in 7 Days'

The subject is positioned centre-left, holding cleaning supplies. The right third of the frame opens up to show the 'friends' label and the suburban background scene. The left edge shows the 'neighbor' label. The asymmetry creates natural visual flow from the subject outward to the context around him - the eye moves from the person to the labels to the scene.

Everything is readable. Nothing is cramped. The composition does the storytelling.

3.3 A/B Split

The screen is divided into two halves showing a transformation: before and after, problem and solution, old way versus new way. Use this for comparison content, results-based videos, or any video where the tension between two states is the core message.

> PROCESS TIP: Before opening Photoshop, sketch the composition. A 10-second rough layout on paper (or even mentally) is the 'measure twice, cut once' step of thumbnail design. Know what goes where before you start building.

3.4 Graphic Element Direction - What to Visualise

When using a graphic as one of your three elements, it needs to immediately represent the desire loop. Four options for what the graphic communicates:

- End state - show the outcome the viewer wants (a revenue screenshot, a full calendar, a result)
- The process - visualise the transformation or journey they'll go through
- Before and after - explicit contrast between the pain state and the solution state
- The pain point - remind them of the problem you're solving, which pulls them toward the solution

The graphic should be immediately readable at small size. If it requires studying to understand, it's the wrong graphic.

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4. Tools and Technical Standards

4.1 Software

- Photoshop - primary design tool for all TikScale thumbnails. This is the standard.
- Remini - used to upscale client photos. If a client's thumbnail photo is low quality or grainy, run it through Remini before bringing it into Photoshop. It makes the subject look significantly sharper and more professional, and most thumbnail designers don't do it.
- Magnific.ai - alternative for upscaling graphic elements or images that need to be enlarged without losing quality

Canva is acceptable for initial concepts or rapid testing, but final deliverables should always be built in Photoshop.

4.2 Photo Standards

The quality of the subject photo has a direct impact on CTR. A blurry or low-quality photo of the client makes the whole thumbnail look amateur. Standards:

- Always run client photos through Remini before use
- Use Photoshop to manually clean up imperfections, whiten eyes slightly, and improve overall crispness
- Remove background and clean the cutout precisely - jagged or rough edges look unprofessional at any size
- If you have multiple photos to choose from, always pick the one with the strongest, most appropriate expression

BEST PRACTICE: Encourage clients (via the strategist) to do a dedicated photo shoot with multiple expressions - happy, shocked, serious, pointing gestures, open hand, closed hand. A library of high-quality poses means you're never forced to use a bad photo. The best channels use the same photos across multiple thumbnails because they're that good.

4.3 File Specs

- Resolution: 1280 x 720 pixels minimum. Export at this size or larger.
- Format: JPG or PNG (JPG for smaller file size, PNG if transparency is involved in the layered file)
- Colour mode: RGB
- Keep the layered PSD file - never deliver a flattened file as your only save

4.4 Concepting - Design Multiple Options

Never deliver a single thumbnail concept. The minimum is two options. Three is the standard. Top YouTube channels test dozens - Steven Bartlett reportedly runs 100 variations per video.

Why this matters: even when you're confident you know what will work, the algorithm decides. The viewer decides. You don't. Three different concepts (not the same concept with different text) gives the strategist options to test and gives the video the best chance of performing.

IMPORTANT: Three different concepts means three fundamentally different approaches - different composition, different primary element, different emotional angle. It does not mean the same thumbnail with different text colours or slightly different fonts. That is one concept, not three.

5. Best Practices and Patterns That Work

5.1 Study What's Working in the Niche

Being good at graphic design is not the same as being good at thumbnail design. The correlation between advanced Photoshop skill and high-performing thumbnails is weak. What matters is understanding the psychology of the click - what patterns work in a specific niche, and why.

Before designing any thumbnail, spend time in the client's niche:

- Search the core topic on YouTube and look at the top-performing videos
- Use TubeBuddy or VidIQ to filter by view count and identify outlier thumbnails
- Look at what visual patterns appear repeatedly in high-view videos - these exist for a reason
- Take note of what the dominant thumbnail style in the niche is - then consider where a different style might stand out

PATTERN EXAMPLE: The 'Diary of a CEO' style - white text, red highlight, black background behind the subject - was so effective that it got adopted across dozens of channels in completely different niches. Why? High contrast, text-first design, credibility. If you see a pattern repeating across top channels, it's working for psychological reasons. Use it.

5.2 The Cognitive Dissonance Thumbnail

One of the most consistent high-performers: a simple design where the text makes a statement that challenges what most people believe. Having a belief challenged creates a strong pull to click and find out why.

How to execute it:

1. Identify a common belief in the client's niche that their content challenges
2. Compress that challenge into four words or fewer
3. Make the text the dominant element - highest contrast, largest font
4. Add a simple visual element that gives context (a face with the right expression, or an image related to the topic)
5. Keep everything else out of the design

EXAMPLES OF STATEMENTS THAT CREATE COGNITIVE DISSONANCE:
- 'You don't need more leads'
- 'Cold email is killing you'
- 'Stop growing your team'
- 'Posting more is wrong'

These work because they contradict the standard advice in the niche. The viewer's brain wants to resolve the contradiction.

5.3 Thumbnail Styles That Consistently Perform for Business/Coaching Channels

Based on patterns across top-performing channels in the business coaching, agency, and creator space:

Results-Forward

Lead with the result. Revenue screenshot, client transformation, specific number. Put the number large and make it impossible to miss. The viewer's desire loop activates immediately.

- Example: '$47k in 30 days' as the dominant text, with a confident face alongside it

Counterintuitive Statement

Text-first design with a statement that challenges conventional wisdom. Simple background, strong contrast, minimal clutter.

- Example: 'Stop Using Calendly' over a clean dark background, small arrow pointing at the text

Before and After / A-B Split

Split screen showing the pain state versus the solution state. Works especially well for transformation content and case studies.

- Example: Left side showing the problem (empty pipeline, stressed face), right side showing the result (calls booked, relaxed)

Authority / Credibility Stamp

Lead with a credibility signal that is impossible to ignore. A large number, a recognisable logo, a well-known name. The click comes from perceived authority.

- Example: '1,500+ clients' or 'We analysed 1,000 ads - here's what we found'

REAL EXAMPLE: 'Best Tech Certifications to Get in 2025 (Full Tier List)'

The background is a collage of certification badges - CompTIA, Cisco, AWS, PMP, and more. This is the maximalist design collage element type in action. Every badge signals credibility and authority in the tech certification space.

The subject has a thoughtful, considered expression (hand near chin) - not shocked, not smiling - which matches the 'authoritative guide' tone of the video. The dominant text 'MUST-HAVE TECH CERT' in large yellow is immediately readable even against a busy background.

This works because the badge collage IS the authority signal. The viewer doesn't need to read the title to understand this person knows their certifications.

5.4 Build a Swipe File

Maintain a running folder of thumbnails you encounter that work. Anytime you see a thumbnail that makes you want to click - screenshot it. Organise by style, by niche, by element type. This is your reference library and it will make you faster and better over time.

- Use TubeBuddy or VidIQ's save feature for thumbnails inside YouTube
- Store locally in a clearly labelled folder, organised by content type or niche
- Review the swipe file before starting any new thumbnail - look for patterns relevant to the current brief
- Share relevant examples with the strategist when concepting, especially if a particular style is working well in the client's niche

5.5 Testing - Let the Market Decide

Never assume you know which thumbnail will perform best. Even experts are wrong. The algorithm and the viewer decide. Your job is to give them options.

Testing tools:

- YouTube's native A/B test tool - simplest option, tests directly in the feed
- ThumbnailTest.com - allows testing multiple variations with title combinations
- ClickPilot.app - lets you preview how the thumbnail looks in the YouTube explore feed and sidebar, including against specific competitor channels

MINIMUM STANDARD: Deliver 2-3 distinct concepts per video. The strategist selects which to use or coordinates A/B testing. You are responsible for the quality and distinctiveness of the concepts. The market decides which wins.

6. Quality Check Criteria

Before you submit any thumbnail concept, run it against this checklist. This is what the strategist will check during QA. Catch the issues yourself and save everyone time.

6.1 The Glance Test

- ☐ Thumbnail makes sense at mobile size (roughly 120px wide) in under one second
- ☐ The core message is readable without zooming in or studying
- ☐ The most important element draws the eye first

6.2 Element Discipline

- ☐ Maximum three design elements in the frame
- ☐ No small details that disappear at thumbnail size
- ☐ Nothing placed in the bottom-right corner (covered by YouTube timestamp)
- ☐ Each element is clearly identifiable at mobile size

6.3 Text Quality

- ☐ Text is the highest contrast element on the page (or intentionally subordinate to the image)
- ☐ Four words or fewer where text is used
- ☐ Font size is large enough to read on a phone screen without zooming
- ☐ Text does not repeat what the title already says - it adds something new
- ☐ Text colour contrasts sharply with whatever is behind it

6.4 Image Quality

- ☐ Subject photo has been run through Remini if it was low quality
- ☐ Background removal is clean - no rough edges or missed areas
- ☐ Saturation and brightness have been adjusted to make the image pop
- ☐ Shadows used where needed to separate subject from background
- ☐ Eyes are clear and sharp - whites are white

6.5 Concept Alignment

- ☐ Thumbnail reinforces the desire loop for this specific video - it's not generic
- ☐ Face expression (if used) matches the emotional tone of the video
- ☐ Thumbnail and title work together - thumbnail does not repeat the title
- ☐ Graphic element (if used) immediately represents the desire loop
- ☐ Color choices contrast with the dominant style in the client's niche

6.6 Deliverable Standards

- ☐ Minimum 2 distinct concepts delivered (3 is the standard)
- ☐ Each concept is genuinely different - not the same design with different text
- ☐ Exported at correct resolution (1280 x 720 minimum)
- ☐ PSD file saved and available
- ☐ Delivered on time - thumbnail is needed before the video goes live

BENCHMARK: A thumbnail that passes all six checklists is ready to deliver. A thumbnail that fails the glance test or the element discipline check goes back for revision before the strategist sees it.

7. Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake 1: Too Many Elements

The single most common mistake. A thumbnail with five or six elements feels complete in the design file and completely illegible in the feed. Cut it down. Three is the maximum. Two often works better than three.

Mistake 2: Thumbnail Repeats the Title

If the title says 'How to Get Clients Without Ads' and the thumbnail text also says 'Get Clients Without Ads', you've wasted the thumbnail. The viewer reads both at the same time. They need to work together, not repeat each other. The thumbnail should add an emotional layer, a number, a result, or a challenge - not a summary of the title.

Mistake 3: Wrong Facial Expression

Using a neutral or smiling face on a video about a common mistake. Using a shocked face on a calm strategy breakdown. The expression on the face unconsciously communicates the viewer experience. Get it right or don't use the face.

Mistake 4: Treating It Like Graphic Design

Thumbnail design and graphic design are different skills. A beautiful, professionally designed thumbnail that doesn't trigger the desire loop will underperform a rough thumbnail that does. Stop optimising for how it looks in the file. Optimise for whether it gets clicked in the feed.

Mistake 5: Using a Bad Photo

A blurry, low-resolution, or poorly lit photo of the client damages the whole thumbnail's credibility. Always upscale through Remini. Clean it up in Photoshop. If the only available photo is genuinely unusable, flag it to the strategist before designing. Don't try to make a bad photo work.

Mistake 6: Designing One Concept

Delivering one thumbnail and expecting it to be the right one is the same mindset as posting one cold email and expecting a response. Three concepts minimum. Different compositions, different emotional angles, different primary elements. Let the strategist and the algorithm choose.

Mistake 7: Ignoring the Niche

Designing a thumbnail without looking at what's working in the client's specific niche first. The niche context tells you what style conventions exist (to follow or deliberately break), what visual language the audience already responds to, and where differentiation is possible. Always research before you design.

Mistake 8: Rushing

Thumbnails are often the last thing done before a video goes live, which means they get rushed. This is backwards. The thumbnail is what determines whether anyone watches the video at all. If you're running out of time, a simple, clean, high-contrast design is better than a complex one built under pressure.